

played by a young Lee Marvin. Much of the violence occurs offscreen, but that reduces none of the movie's power—honesty may win out in the end, but only after exacting a terrible cost. The movie is the ultimate refinement of Lang's realistic, brutal style.

See also: *Metropolis* 32–33 ■
M 46–47

LA STRADA

Federico Fellini, 1954

Fellini's *La Strada* (*The Road*) can be seen as his reaction against the neorealist movement of which he had been part. It is a determinedly unrealistic fable of three circus performers, for whom a theatrical façade hides their inner sadness. The strongman Zampanò buys the waif Gelsomina from her mother to be his comic foil, but he continually abuses her, until she eventually leaves him for high-wire artist Il Matto. In a fit of jealousy Zampanò kills Il Matto, and Gelsomina is desolate. The movie features Fellini's trademark visual themes, such as figures suspended between heaven and earth, and a desolate seashore.

See also: *La Dolce Vita* 160–65

SEVEN SAMURAI

Akira Kurosawa, 1954

Kurosawa's *Seven Samurai* was inspired by Hollywood Westerns, and it, in turn, inspired the Western *The Magnificent Seven*, but it is very much a Japanese movie, steeped in the traditions of the Samurai warrior class and notions of honor. The story is a simple one—seven warriors band together to protect a village against bandits—but Kurosawa's stunning

visual style and fast-paced editing, plus his ability to give scenes a huge emotional kick, turn it into an epic of true heroism. The movie is also a study in Japanese social mores, as two mutually distrustful social classes uneasily come together in pursuit of a common cause.

See also: *Rashomon* 108–13

RIFI

Jules Dassin, 1955

In French heist movie *Rifi*, the robbery of a jewelry store on Paris's Rue de Rivoli takes place in 20 minutes of almost total silence. The effect was so believable that some critics have called the movie a guide for criminals. Dassin hated the novel on which the movie was based (he changed the villains' ethnicity to make the story less racist), but this only made him work harder to give the movie both tension and heart, paying meticulous attention to detail in a way that was to be imitated later by movies such as Quentin Tarantino's *Reservoir Dogs*.

INVASION OF THE BODY SNATCHERS

Don Siegel, 1956

Invasion of the Body Snatchers is a science-fiction thriller that reflects the paranoia of the Cold War era. The idea is simple: a doctor is mystified when all his patients complain to him that their families have been replaced by impostors. He soon discovers that the town has been colonized by alien seedpods that can replicate humans in all but their emotions. The movie has been seen as a

political allegory, but it is unclear whether its message is attacking communism, or the oppression and paranoia created by McCarthyism.

TOUCH OF EVIL

Orson Welles, 1958

Crime thriller *Touch of Evil* was one of the last of the classic film noirs. It is extravagantly theatrical, with the gigantic presence—literally and figuratively—of Orson Welles, who wrote and directed the movie, and who also plays the bent and bloated cop Quinlan. Set on the Mexico–US border, the story focuses on a Mexican drug enforcement official (Charlton Heston), who realizes that Quinlan is corrupt. The movie is famous for its uninterrupted, three-minute-long crane tracking sequence, which moves slowly through four blocks of the troubled town.

See also: *Citizen Kane* 66–71

ASCENSEUR POUR L'ÉCHAFAUD

Louis Malle, 1958

Known as *Elevator to the Gallows* in the US and *Lift to the Scaffold* elsewhere, Louis Malle's *Ascenseur pour l'échafaud* is a dark thriller about a pair of lovers, Florence (Jeanne Moreau) and Julien (Maurice Ronet), who plot to murder Florence's husband. The plan goes horribly wrong when Julien is trapped in an elevator on his way from the crime scene. The claustrophobic shots of Paris at night give the movie a noirish feel, but there is a sense of realism that anticipates the French New Wave. The action is accompanied by an atmospheric jazz score from Miles Davis.